

01 Master Business Travel Policy

India-focused synthetic enterprise reference policy | Version 1.0 | Effective 01 January 2026

PROVENANCE: This is a synthetic reference implementation created for RAG development. It is not an actual company policy. Production use requires replacement with the adopting company's approved policy, limits, grades and approval matrix.

1. Scope, Purpose & Definitions

Purpose

This policy establishes a controlled framework for authorizing, booking, paying, documenting and reimbursing business travel and related expenses in India and for international business trips originating in India.

Business travel must be necessary, reasonable, economical and connected to an approved business purpose. Limits are ceilings, not spending targets.

Where this policy refers to an approved channel, supplier, rate card, employee grade or approval authority, the production organization must populate those values from its current controlled source.

Definitions

Business trip means approved travel away from the employee's normal work location for company business. Domestic travel means travel within India; international travel means travel crossing an international border.

Per diem means a fixed daily allowance where the applicable rate card permits fixed-rate reimbursement instead of actual documented meals.

Personal expense means a cost primarily for personal convenience, leisure or private travel and is not reimbursable unless expressly allowed.

Core controls

Employees must not split, duplicate or deliberately misclassify expenses to avoid a limit or approval requirement.

An approved expense must still satisfy the applicable policy rule. Manager approval does not convert a prohibited expense into an eligible expense.

Questions requiring live information such as airline schedules, current exchange rates or current tax law should be answered using the relevant live system rather than a static policy.

2. Eligibility & Travel Authorization

Eligibility

Employees, approved contractors and other authorized personnel may travel for customer meetings, project delivery, site visits, training, audits, conferences, business development and other approved purposes.

Normal home-to-office commuting is not business travel.

Pre-trip approval

Domestic overnight travel should normally be approved before booking. International travel requires documented approval before ticket issuance.

The request should identify traveler, destination, dates, business purpose, cost center, project/customer, estimated cost and required approvers.

Emergency travel may be booked before normal approval only where delay would materially affect business operations; retrospective approval must be completed promptly.

Changes

Business-driven itinerary changes are reimbursable when documented. Personal itinerary changes are the employee's responsibility.

Employees should use refunds, credits or vouchers for future business travel where practical rather than allowing company-funded value to expire.

3. Air Travel & Flights

Booking

Air tickets should be booked through the approved corporate travel channel. Direct booking is an exception when the channel cannot satisfy the requirement or an emergency exists.

Employees should select a reasonable itinerary based on total journey time, fare, baggage and business need. Flexible or fully refundable fares should be selected only where itinerary uncertainty justifies the premium.

Cabin class

Domestic flights are normally economy class unless an approved exception applies.

International flights are normally economy class. Premium economy or business class may be allowed for designated grades or qualifying long-haul journeys under the organization's grade matrix.

Personal upgrades are not reimbursable unless the employee was explicitly authorized to travel in that cabin.

Baggage & seats

Standard checked and cabin baggage associated with an eligible fare is reimbursable. Additional baggage is reimbursable when required for business equipment, samples, documents or other approved materials.

Preferred seats and extra-legroom seats are reimbursable only when required for business, accessibility or an approved long-haul rule.

Lounge access is reimbursable only when included in an eligible fare/program or expressly approved.

Cancellations & disruptions

Airline cancellation, material schedule disruption and involuntary rerouting are business travel events. Reasonable replacement transport is reimbursable when necessary for approved business travel.

Reasonable accommodation and meals caused by a disruption may be claimed when the airline does not provide them and the costs are documented.

Voluntary cancellation for personal reasons is not reimbursable.

4. Rail, Bus & Intercity Road

Rail

Rail may be selected when practical, safe and cost-effective compared with air travel. Eligible class is determined by the grade/rate matrix.

Business-related cancellation charges are reimbursable when the cancellation was caused by an approved business change.

Road

Approved intercity taxis, buses and hired cars may be used when rail or air is impractical.

Self-drive intercity travel requires prior approval and compliance with vehicle, insurance and safety requirements.

Fuel, tolls and parking for approved business travel are reimbursable when supported by receipts or an approved mileage method.

5. Hotel & Accommodation

Booking & limits

Hotels should be booked through approved channels. Employees must select a property within the applicable city and grade limit.

Hotel limits are maximum nightly amounts. Production rate cards should specify whether taxes are included or reimbursed separately.

Where the approved rate is unavailable, the employee should document the search and obtain the required exception approval when practical.

Room and services

Business-use internet is reimbursable when necessary and not included in the room rate.

Breakfast included in an eligible room rate is part of the room expense. Separately purchased breakfast follows meal rules.

Laundry may be reimbursable for eligible extended or international trips. Mini-bar, movies, spa, personal room service and leisure charges are not reimbursable.

Cancellation/no-show

Business-driven hotel cancellation fees are reimbursable when documented. No-show fees caused by personal error without a business reason may be rejected.

Refundable rates should be considered when itinerary uncertainty is material and the incremental cost is justified.

6. Meals, Food & Business Entertainment

Meals

Reasonable meals during approved travel are reimbursable subject to the applicable meal or daily limit.

Breakfast, lunch and dinner eligibility depends on travel timing and the applicable rate card. Meals during normal office attendance are not reimbursable unless part of an approved business event.

When per diem is used, the same meal must not also be claimed as an actual expense.

Client meals

Client meals require a genuine business purpose and should record the date, supplier, amount and participants or customer relationship where required.

Above-limit meals or meals involving external guests may require additional approval.

Alcohol is not reimbursable as a personal meal expense. Any business entertainment involving alcohol must comply with the separate entertainment and compliance rules.

Entertainment

Business entertainment must be modest, reasonable, lawful and connected to a genuine business purpose. Personal social events and leisure entertainment are excluded.

7. Local Transportation

Taxi, app cab & public transport

Reasonable taxi, app-based cab, metro, bus and other public transport are reimbursable for approved business travel.

Uber, Ola and comparable services may be used where available, subject to the approved service level and documentation requirements.

Premium or luxury ride categories require a business justification or exception approval.

Rental cars

Rental cars may be used where practical or economical for the business need, including when transporting equipment or multiple travelers.

Compact or standard vehicles should normally be selected. Fuel, tolls, parking and approved rental insurance are reimbursable.

Traffic fines and personal violations are not reimbursable.

Personal vehicle

Business use of a personal vehicle may be reimbursed using the approved mileage rate or eligible actual costs, but not both for the same distance.

Claims should include date, origin, destination, business purpose and distance. Home-to-office commuting is excluded.

8. International Business Travel

Pre-travel

International travel requires business approval and completion of passport, visa, immigration and destination requirements.

Business visa fees are reimbursable when required for approved travel. General personal passport issuance is normally not reimbursable.

Foreign currency

Foreign expenses should be claimed in original currency and converted using the corporate card statement rate, approved exchange rate or finance-prescribed method.

Reasonable foreign exchange or bank charges directly caused by approved business travel may be reimbursable.

Insurance and disruption

Corporate travel insurance or approved travel insurance may cover eligible business travel risks. Duplicate personal coverage is not reimbursable.

Emergency accommodation and transport caused by covered disruption may be reimbursable subject to documentation and any insurance recovery.

Personal extension / bleisure

Employees may extend a business trip for personal reasons only when permitted and when the company bears no additional cost caused by the personal extension.

Additional personal hotel nights, meals, transportation, fare differences and other private costs are the employee's responsibility.

9. Communication Expenses

Mobile, roaming & data

Business mobile usage during approved travel may be reimbursed under the corporate plan or approved roaming package.

International roaming should use the approved provider where available. Personal calls, premium content and entertainment are excluded.

Temporary SIMs and data plans may be reimbursed when necessary for approved international business travel and properly documented.

Internet & meeting costs

Hotel internet, business connectivity and conference communication charges may be reimbursed when required and not already provided.

Employees should use corporate communication tools for sensitive business information.

10. Expense Claim & Receipts

Submission

Expense reports should normally be submitted within 15 calendar days after the trip, subject to the organization's controlled finance deadline.

Each line should include date, merchant, amount, currency, category, business purpose and cost center/project/customer when applicable.

Receipts must be legible and attached electronically.

Receipts

Original or digital supplier receipts are required above the applicable threshold and for designated mandatory-receipt categories.

Airfare, hotel, rental car and visa expenses normally require supporting documentation regardless of amount.

When a receipt is unavailable, the employee must use the missing-receipt declaration and provide an explanation; additional approval may be required.

Tax invoices

GST invoices should contain required tax details when input tax credit is intended. Employees should provide the company's GSTIN to suppliers where instructed.

Tax treatment must follow current finance and tax guidance rather than assumptions in the travel policy.

11. Approval Matrix & Exceptions

Standard workflow

Employee certifies accuracy and business purpose. Line manager confirms business necessity. Finance verifies documentation, policy compliance and accounting treatment.

Premium cabin, above-limit hotel, exceptional transportation and unusual entertainment require the additional authority defined by the controlled approval matrix.

Exceptions

Exceptions should identify the rule, reason, incremental cost, duration and approving authority. Approval should be obtained before the expense where practical.

Emergency exceptions may be documented after the event where advance approval was impossible.

Disputes

Rejected claims may be resubmitted with additional evidence or escalated through the designated finance process.

Policy interpretation should use the policy version effective on the date of travel.

12. Non-Reimbursable Expenses

Examples

Personal shopping, minibar, movies, spa, leisure activities, personal travel, traffic fines, family travel, ordinary commuting, personal insurance and personal upgrades are not reimbursable.

Luxury services selected solely for personal convenience are not reimbursable.

Duplicate claims, altered receipts, fictitious expenses and deliberate misclassification are prohibited.

Edge cases

Lost baggage purchases may be reimbursable only where necessary for business and after considering airline compensation or insurance.

Personal credit-card annual fees are not reimbursable unless the card was issued specifically for company business.

Reasonable ATM or exchange fees directly caused by approved business travel may be reimbursable.

13. RAG Grounding & Metadata

Retrieval rules

Every answer should be grounded in a policy section and effective date. The agent should return the relevant rule, condition, documentation requirement and approval requirement.

When multiple rules apply, the more specific rule controls the general rule, subject to effective date and employee/destination metadata.

If the policy does not specify a limit, the agent must say that the policy does not specify the amount rather than inventing one.

Recommended chunk metadata

tenant_id, company, country, policy_id, policy_version, effective_from, effective_to, section, category, subcategory, expense_type, employee_grade, destination_city, domestic_international, approval_required, receipt_required, source_document.

Keep section headings with every chunk. Do not mix different companies' limits in one tenant.

Answer format

A strong answer should state eligibility, limit/condition, required documentation, approval requirement and policy reference.

For ambiguous questions, ask for the missing fact such as destination, employee grade, travel dates, domestic/international status or expense type.